Mother in Heaven

The Belief Files

Case File 007

Historical investigation and biblical assessment

Beyond the Message | LDS origins and authority | November 2026

Investigation summary

Latter-day Saint teaching identifies human beings as spirit children of heavenly parents, including a Heavenly Mother. This case investigates how that belief appears in the historical record, what supports its attribution to Joseph Smith, and how it compares with Scripture. The question concerns the identity of God and the grounds for religious authority, while also touching beliefs about family and human destiny. [1–2, 6–10]

Publications from 1845 establish that the idea circulated early in the movement. Later recollections connect it with Smith, but those recollections must be dated as later reports of earlier conversations. The Church acknowledges that no formal revelation to Smith on this doctrine is recorded; it also describes the teaching as revealed. Those statements answer different questions and should both remain visible. [2–5, 9]

The historical finding is that an early belief received sustained institutional affirmation. That does not independently establish the existence of the divine person described. From this project's evangelical and Trinitarian Christian perspective, the further issue is whether the heavenly parent framework is warranted by the biblical account of God, creation, adoption, and eternal life. The evidence reviewed does not demonstrate deliberate invention or dishonesty by Smith or by the people who transmitted the teaching.

The claim under investigation

The investigation separates several propositions:

- People lived as spirit children of heavenly parents before mortal life. Official LDS instruction connects this parentage with their potential to become like God through Christ. This is a claim about human origins, not simply a poetic description of God's kindness. [6–7, 10]
- A Heavenly Mother belongs within that account of divine parentage. Early publications express the idea, and later accounts attribute teaching about her to Joseph Smith. The dates and transmission of those records require separate examination. [3–5]
- Authorized leaders affirm the doctrine while limiting what they say is known. Their public instruction directs prayer to Heavenly Father in the name of Jesus Christ rather than to Heavenly Mother. [8–9]
- The doctrine relates to the LDS understanding of eternal marriage and exaltation, the highest promised celestial glory. This must be distinguished from every LDS use of salvation. [8, 11]

These claims should be stated as LDS teaching before they are evaluated. Calling the belief mere unofficial folklore would overlook the sources. Saying that Latter-day Saints are instructed to pray to a goddess would misdescribe the published prayer guidance. Neither correction prevents a substantive Christian disagreement about the doctrine of God.

How this investigation weighs evidence

Date the document and the reported event separately. A book published in 1911 may report a conversation associated with 1839. Its publication date is evidence for the surviving report; it is not the date of a contemporary transcript.

Ask what each source actually witnesses. A poem directly documents its author's public expression. A recollection can preserve a claim about earlier instruction. A leadership statement establishes an institution's teaching. None of these functions automatically verifies the supernatural claim described.

Preserve the strongest explanation. LDS advocates appeal to revelation and prophetic authority, not only to the reasoning of a hymn. The Christian response must address that authority claim rather than treating the entire belief as an accidental poetic phrase.

Use the same standard for Christian inference. Christians also reason across passages and use doctrinal terms that do not appear as single biblical words. The relevant question is whether an interpretation faithfully explains the texts, not merely whether its preferred label appears in a verse.

Distinguish theological disagreement from a judgment about people. A claim can be historically uncertain or biblically unwarranted without its adherents being unintelligent, insincere, or indifferent to Scripture. A person's experience of family and belonging does not settle the argument in either direction.

The historical timeline

Date	Record or development	Investigative significance
1839 as the reported setting	Gates's later account relates a conversation between Zina D. Huntington and Joseph Smith after Zina's mother's death. [5]	The alleged conversation and its surviving publication must not be assigned the same date.
January 15 1845	William W. Phelps's Come to Me appears in Times and Seasons, page 783, referring to a heavenly Father and Mother. [3]	Published evidence precedes Snow's better-known poem.
October and November 1845	Snow dates My Father in Heaven to October; it appears in Times and Seasons on November 15. [4]	The text is an early public expression after Smith's death.
November 1909	The First Presidency issues The Origin of Man. [6]	Divine parentage appears in an institutional declaration, not only in poetry.
1911	Susa Young Gates publishes the account attributed to Zina D. Young. [5]	A named chain of recollection survives, decades after the reported event.
October 1991	Gordon B. Hinckley's Daughters of God discusses both exaltation and prayer. [8]	The talk distinguishes belief in Heavenly Mother from permission to address prayers to her.
1995	The Family proclamation is issued by the First Presidency and the Twelve. [7]	Heavenly parentage is reaffirmed in a joint declaration.
April 2022	Dale G. Renlund addresses revelation, limited knowledge, speculation, and prayer. [9]	A later explanation supplies the LDS position that must be considered alongside the historical record.

Exhibit one The early publications

Phelps's January 1845 poem expressly includes a heavenly Mother. Its existence prevents an account in which Snow's later poem first introduced the idea into every form of public LDS expression. It provides a dated text, not a verbatim record of Smith announcing a revelation. A literary work written in a prophetic voice must still be identified as Phelps's composition. [3]

Snow's poem presents a remembered premortal home and a hoped-for return to divine parents. Its reasoning connects heavenly fatherhood with motherhood. Readers can inspect that movement within the poem without assuming that its emotional appeal establishes its theology. The original publication identifies its author and date; it supplies no transcript of Smith privately instructing her. [4]

The poem is also not a systematic account of the divine family. A reader should not extract a detailed mechanism of spirit birth, an identity for Heavenly Mother, or a complete account of her activities from language that does not supply those things. A short text can express a consequential belief while leaving many questions unanswered.

Chronology places a specific limit on one argument sometimes made about the poem. In his 1991 talk, Hinckley recounted others' reasoning that Smith had not corrected Snow's words. The poem's published date follows Smith's death, so his failure to correct that publication cannot establish his approval of it. That observation does not establish that he never taught the underlying idea privately. The latter question depends on other evidence. [4, 8]

A sound historical conclusion is narrower than either extreme: the idea was publicly expressed in 1845, and Snow supplied an enduring formulation. Those facts do not show that she invented it, that every later detail existed at the outset, or that the poem's account of heaven is independently verified.

Exhibit two Recollections about Joseph Smith

Gates's 1911 history reports a story that, she says, Zina D. Young told her and others during Zina's life. The story connects Zina's grief for her deceased mother with Smith's assurance about an eternal Mother. Gates identifies a source for her account. She does not present herself as an eyewitness to the earlier conversation. [5]

That distinction matters. The narrative setting is associated with 1839, while the book was published seventy-two years later. The publication date does not tell us precisely when Zina first related the story, nor does it demonstrate that she waited seventy-two years to tell it. It does show why the text should not be introduced as an 1839 diary entry or a contemporary record in Smith's own hand.

The Church Historian's Press edition of Snow's poem also cites a March 16, 1916 letter from David McKay, the father of David O. McKay. Its editorial note reports his recollection of Snow attributing the teaching to Smith. This is an additional route of attribution through remembered conversation. In this case it is reported through the editors' note; the archival letter has not been independently examined. The father and son must not be confused. [4]

These reports have historical value because they identify people close to the early movement and preserve a remembered source for the belief. Their limitations also remain: time elapsed, conversations were transmitted, and exact wording cannot be tested against an available contemporary transcript of the reported private instruction. Agreement in attribution deserves consideration without being converted into several independent observations of a divine being.

The absence of a recorded formal revelation leaves the origin less directly documented than a surviving dated revelation would. It does not logically establish that no instruction or religious experience occurred. Equally, the possibility of unrecorded instruction does not supply its missing words, date, or circumstances.

Exhibit three Institutional teaching and prayer

The 1909 First Presidency statement describes men and women as literal offspring of a divine Father and Mother. It also speaks of God as Creator and interprets humanity's development through celestial parentage. The Christian comparison should therefore examine what the source means by creation and divine offspring rather than claiming that LDS teaching has no language of creation at all. The text used here is the Church's 2002 reprint, which states that editorial features such as spelling and punctuation were standardized. [6]

The 1995 Family proclamation likewise places heavenly parentage beside creation in God's image. It joins premortal identity, earthly experience, and the continuation of family relationships through temple ordinances. This provides clear evidence of institutional affirmation. It is a later doctrinal declaration, not another eyewitness account of something Smith said in the 1830s. [7]

Gospel Principles chapter 2 makes the premortal claim explicit: people are understood as literal spirit children before their earthly lives. This is why translating every use of heavenly parents into a harmless metaphor would miss the doctrine under investigation. At the same time, this lesson attributes the possibility of becoming like God to Christ's Atonement. The system should not be described as if Christ were absent from its own explanation. [10]

Hinckley taught that prayer to Heavenly Mother was inappropriate under the scriptural pattern he accepted. His talk also affirmed women's eligibility for celestial glory and addressed faithful people without an opportunity for marriage. Reporting the marriage teaching while omitting that latter assurance would distort his position. [8]

Renlund's 2022 address describes the doctrine as coming through revelation, acknowledges how little is known, cautions against speculation, and repeats the instruction about prayer. His claim of revelation and the essay's acknowledgment of no recorded formal revelation to Smith can both be stated accurately. One concerns the Church's understanding of authority; the

other concerns the surviving documentary record. Whether the claimed revelation is warranted remains the question to assess. [2, 9]

Assessing the principal accounts

Source	What it can establish	Limit on the inference
Phelps's 1845 poem	An early published reference to heavenly Mother. [3]	Literary expression is not a transcript of Smith or independent verification of heaven.
Snow's 1845 poem	Her public articulation of divine parentage and premortal identity. [4]	The text alone does not establish where she first learned the idea.
Zina's account as published by Gates	A reported attribution to Smith through an identified chain of memory. [5]	The 1911 publication is not a contemporary 1839 record.
McKay's reported recollection	Another remembered attribution, cited by historical editors. [4]	This case has not independently examined the archival letter.
Later declarations and instruction	Institutional affirmation and stated limits on prayer and speculation. [6–10]	Later agreement does not create additional eyewitnesses to the alleged original revelation.

Sources should not be counted as if every citation were an independent witness to the same event. An essay may cite an edited history that cites a recollection. The reader is following a chain of transmission, not necessarily encountering three separate observations.

Nor does shared institutional commitment make every source worthless. A believer may preserve accurate history, and a critic may identify a genuine inconsistency. The appropriate questions concern access, date, genre, transmission, and what can be checked. Religious affiliation alone supplies neither automatic acceptance nor automatic rejection.

There are two different conclusions to keep apart. The surviving sources support the history of a belief and its later authority within the Church. Establishing the reality of the heavenly parentage described requires a further argument. Accepting Smith's prophetic authority would substantially affect that judgment, which is why authority cannot simply be assumed at the point where it is being investigated.

The strongest LDS argument

The strongest defense appeals to continuing revelation, memories of early teaching, and subsequent authoritative affirmation. It understands biblical language about God's image, divine offspring, and the relation of men and women as consistent with a fuller revealed account. On this view, the lack of one preserved formal revelation is a gap in documentation rather than a refutation of the doctrine. [5–7, 9–11]

That argument deserves a direct response. A historical investigator should not demand a transcript for an LDS claim while treating every ancient Christian conversation as fully recoverable. A Christian also cannot reject a doctrine solely because it is expressed through a later theological term. Both sides must explain why their sources and interpretations deserve confidence.

The remaining difficulty is that consistency with a framework is not independent confirmation of the framework. A heavenly mother follows more readily once literal divine parentage and continuing prophetic authority are accepted. Those premises are part of what the Christian reader is evaluating. The argument must therefore show why the proposed revelation should be trusted and how its reading of Scripture accounts for the relevant passages.

The LDS position is also stronger when it admits limits. Acknowledging a doctrine does not authorize a reader to fill every silence with personal speculation. Conversely, restraint about details does not by itself establish the central claim. The investigator should assess what is actually taught and the support offered for it.

Competing explanations

Revealed teaching preserved through several forms

Smith taught the doctrine privately, early associates expressed it publicly, and later leaders preserved or clarified the truth through authorized teaching. This account can explain the recollections and institutional continuity. Its decisive premise is divine authorization, which the publication history alone does not independently verify.

Theological development in the early movement

The belief developed through reflection on divine fatherhood, premortal life, marriage, and human potential. Poetry, remembered teaching, and later declarations helped transmit it. This explanation fits the existence of a developing religious tradition, but identifying its precise origin or assigning particular ideas to particular people requires more evidence than a general account of development.

Early teaching followed by later elaboration

Some form of the idea existed in Smith's circle, while its wording, status, and wider implications became clearer over time. This possibility recognizes that continuity and development can coexist. It does not determine how much of the later doctrine was taught by Smith or whether any stage was divinely revealed.

Conscious fabrication for institutional benefit

A critic may argue that authority claims were knowingly constructed to strengthen allegiance or a family-centered theology. To establish that explanation, evidence of deliberate misrepresentation is needed. The usefulness of a belief and the lateness of a report do not independently demonstrate that its author knew it was false.

These explanations are not all mutually exclusive at the descriptive level. A believer may regard development as guided by revelation, while a critic regards the same sequence as human interpretation. The evidence can

establish dates and texts more securely than it can establish private intent or divine action.

Motives benefits and costs

The teaching can give people a way to understand belonging, motherhood, and women's eternal significance. Those meanings should be heard from the person being addressed rather than assigned to every LDS woman or family. A belief's ability to comfort does not establish its truth, but its comfort is not evidence of dishonesty either.

Institutional teaching also shapes who may define doctrine and which religious practices are authorized. A question about prayer or revelation can therefore become a question about allegiance and trust, not merely an abstract disagreement. Christians should recognize that practical setting when deciding how to speak.

The same scrutiny applies to the Christian investigator. A desire to win an argument can encourage selective quotation, exaggerated claims about missing evidence, or a caricature of another person's faith. Truthful witness requires that the strongest response and the relevant qualifications remain in the comparison. [19]

A biblical assessment

The one God and Christian inference

Deuteronomy 6:4 and Isaiah 44:6-8 affirm God's uniqueness. First Corinthians 8:4-6 places the one God and the one Lord Jesus Christ in relation to the origin and existence of all things. John 1:1-3 identifies the Word with God while distinguishing him from God, and Matthew 28:19 names Father, Son, and Holy Ghost together. The project's Trinitarian reading brings these passages into a coherent account of the one divine being. [13]

This is an interpretation across texts, not a claim that one verse supplies every later theological definition. Christians should explain that reasoning

openly. Catholic, Orthodox, and Protestant traditions also differ about the relation of Scripture, tradition, and doctrinal development. This case's evangelical perspective should not be passed off as an exhaustive description of every Christian method.

The substantive objection to Heavenly Mother concerns the content of the proposed extension. Within the project's reading, Scripture identifies the Creator and the divine identity without establishing another divine person as the Father's spouse. The Christian must explain that account from the texts; the LDS respondent must explain why the heavenly parent framework follows from them or why a later revelation should govern their interpretation. An absent doctrinal label, by itself, cannot settle either claim.

God's image and maternal care

Genesis 1:26-27 explicitly includes male and female humanity in God's image. Women therefore share that dignity directly; their value does not depend on proving that a separate divine female parent exists. The passage's plural language deserves interpretation, but the text does not identify a husband and wife producing human spirits. [12]

Scripture also uses maternal imagery. In Isaiah 66:13 the Lord compares his comfort with a mother's comfort; the surrounding passage portrays Jerusalem in maternal terms. A Christian account should acknowledge such language instead of implying that all maternal descriptions of divine care are unbiblical. An image of motherly care and a distinct Heavenly Mother are different claims. The former does not, without further argument, establish the latter. [14]

This distinction leaves room to discuss what the imagery actually communicates: comfort, dependence, nourishment, and belonging. It does not require dismissing those experiences to defend monotheism. The issue is whether the passage identifies another divine being or describes the care of the God already speaking.

Divine offspring and adoption through Christ

Acts 17:24-29 calls human beings God's offspring in a speech that also identifies him as maker of the world and giver of life. Christians should not deny that this broader language about humanity's relationship to God exists. The question is what it entails. The passage does not describe a heavenly mother or a process of spirit birth. [15]

John 1:12-13 speaks of becoming God's children through receiving Christ, and Romans 8:14-17 describes adoption and inheritance through the Spirit. These passages concern the saving relationship of believers with God. That relationship should not be collapsed into every broader sense in which humanity depends on its Creator. [16]

LDS teaching can likewise distinguish premortal parentage from a later covenant relationship with Christ, so citing adoption is not a complete reply to everything it claims. The further question is whether the texts warrant the additional universal premortal birth narrative. From this project's perspective, creation, new birth, and adoption explain human dignity and salvation without supplying evidence for a divine parental couple. The disagreement requires comparing meanings, not simply repeating the shared word children.

Interdependence marriage and eternal life

First Corinthians 11:11-12 describes the interdependence of man and woman in the Lord. The surrounding discussion concerns worship, relations between men and women, creation, and birth. Paul also attributes everything to God. The text does not identify a Heavenly Mother or explicitly prescribe eternal marriage as a condition of exaltation. [17]

The LDS application must be considered alongside Doctrine and Covenants 131:1-4 and 132:19-20, where the marriage and exaltation connection is explicit. Those sources establish the LDS claim more directly; they do not establish that Paul taught that claim. This distinction allows the reader to examine a proposed interpretation rather than treating a later application as the plain wording of an earlier passage. [11]

Matthew 22:23-33 presents Jesus' answer to a resurrection problem involving successive marriages. LDS interpreters distinguish marriages made after resurrection from prior authorized sealings; the Christian question is whether Jesus' answer supports that distinction. First Corinthians 7 also honors unmarried service. A Christian argument should engage the actual LDS response while explaining why the New Testament does not make marriage a condition of receiving eternal life in Christ. [18]

This criticism must not turn into the assertion that faithful single LDS people are automatically denied every promised blessing. Hinckley's assurance addresses people without an opportunity for marriage. The disagreement concerns the claimed eternal requirement and its authority, not a claim that the Church ignores that circumstance. [8]

Prayer and the sufficiency of Christ

Matthew 6:9 supplies Jesus' pattern of prayer to the Father. Ephesians 2:18 describes access through Christ by one Spirit. The Christian comparison can acknowledge a shared reference to prayer to the Father without assuming that the two traditions mean the same thing by divine identity. [19]

Nor should Christians claim that the New Testament prohibits every direct address to Jesus: Acts 7:59 records Stephen calling upon him. The comparison here concerns the warrant for Heavenly Mother, not an unnecessary restriction on all Christian prayer. Whether a person is prayed to and whether that person is believed to exist are separate questions.

The positive Christian invitation rests on God's saving work in Christ. Ephesians 2:8-10 places salvation in grace through faith and connects the resulting life with good works. First John 5:11-13 locates eternal life in the Son. From this project's perspective, a person does not need to establish a heavenly marriage pattern to receive that life. A conversation should make that hope clear rather than end only with an objection to someone else's belief. [19]

Findings and confidence

Confidence refers to the particular historical or textual finding and its stated support. It is not a numerical probability assigned to divine revelation.

Finding	Confidence	Basis and limit
Heavenly Mother appeared in early public LDS writing.	High	Dated publications in 1845, including Phelps before Snow. [3–4]
Surviving later accounts attribute teaching to Smith.	High for the existence of the reports	Gates's account and an editorially cited McKay letter; exact earlier wording remains less directly documented. [4–5]
A formal revelation to Smith on this doctrine is recorded.	Not established	The Church's essay acknowledges the documentary absence. That is not proof that no private teaching occurred. [2]
Institutional LDS sources affirm heavenly parentage.	High	First Presidency statement, proclamation, and published instruction. [6–10]
LDS members are instructed to pray to Heavenly Mother.	Contradicted by the guidance reviewed	Hinckley and Renlund direct prayer to the Father in Christ's name. [8–9]
The historical record independently verifies a divine Mother.	Not established	The sources document teaching, memory, and authority claims rather than independent observation of the divine reality.
Development or missing documentation proves deliberate deception.	Not established	Neither fact independently supplies evidence of private knowledge and intent.

Overall assessment

The evidence establishes an early and enduring LDS belief with a substantial history of institutional affirmation. The doctrine should not be dismissed as an isolated lyric or an unauthorized rumor. Its attribution to Smith has surviving testimonial support, but the later reports must not be presented as contemporary transcripts of his private instruction.

The central authority question remains. A publication history can show how a teaching was expressed and received. Accepting that teaching as revealed requires reasons to trust the claimed revelation and its interpretation of Scripture. The lack of a recorded formal revelation is a real limitation; it does not independently prove that the doctrine was knowingly fabricated.

From this project's evangelical and Trinitarian perspective, the biblical passages reviewed support the one Creator, the dignity of women and men, and adoption and eternal life through Christ. They do not establish the additional heavenly parent framework. That is a theological judgment grounded in the stated reading of Scripture, distinguished from the historical finding about what early and later Latter-day Saints taught.

Read compare and discuss

Read the early Phelps reference and Snow's poem alongside the 1911 account attributed to Zina. Put the reported event date and the document date in different columns. Then compare the 1909 statement, the Family proclamation, and Renlund's 2022 explanation. For the biblical assessment, read Genesis 1:26-27, Acts 17:24-29, Romans 8:14-17, and the full context of 1 Corinthians 11:11-12.

1. What can the 1845 publications establish without assuming their theology is true?
2. What does Gates say about her source, and what remains unknown about the earlier conversation?
3. How does a claim of revelation differ from a surviving formal revelation document?

4. Which premises make the strongest LDS argument persuasive to someone who accepts them?
5. What is the difference between maternal imagery and a distinct divine Mother?
6. How would you explain your own Christian use of theological inference consistently?
7. What would cause you to revise a historical conclusion or reconsider an interpretation?

A useful opening is: "When you speak of Heavenly Mother, what does that belief mean to you, and which sources matter most to your understanding?" A follow-up is: "Could we compare the different ways these passages speak about being God's children?" Listen to the answer before explaining what you believe Christ gives to those who receive him.

For a group or family study, compare a dated publication with a later family recollection about an earlier event. Discuss why both can be valuable while answering different questions. Then read Genesis 1 and Romans 8, affirming each person's dignity and distinguishing creation from adoption through Christ. Avoid using a participant's grief, marital status, or experience of motherhood as an argument against that person.

Accuracy notes and further research

- The supplied packet is a working synthesis. Its broad contrasts have been checked or qualified against identified historical texts and official LDS instruction. [1]
- No recorded formal revelation does not mean that LDS leaders concede the doctrine was never revealed. Both the historical acknowledgment and the claim of revelation remain in the case. [2, 9]
- The Phelps and Gates passages were checked in reproduced transcriptions. The entire original volumes were not independently collated; the Gates narrative is not an 1839 document. [3, 5]
- Snow's poem and its publication information were read in the Church Historian's Press edition. Its editorial discussion and the nineteenth-century text are different sources of information within that edition. [4]
- The 1916 McKay letter is reported through the historical editors' citation. This case does not claim inspection of the archival original or date the remembered conversation precisely. [4]
- The 1909 statement was read in a modern authorized reprint. This case does not claim an edition-by-edition comparison of the original printing and the reprint. [6]
- The selected LDS sources do not warrant invented details about Heavenly Mother's identity, the mechanism of spirit birth, or the number of heavenly mothers. Connections with ancient goddesses or the history of plural marriage require their own source review.
- Maternal imagery, universal divine offspring language, and saving adoption must be interpreted in context. Their presence should not be concealed to make the Christian comparison easier. [12–17]
- A future book would benefit from a fuller archival study of the recollections and reception of the doctrine. This case does not present a comprehensive survey of every member's belief or every leadership statement.

Sources and reading

The register distinguishes the supplied research, early published texts, transmitted recollections, later official teaching, and biblical comparison. Web sources were checked November 8, 2026. Biblical citations use the KJV; publisher headings and interpretive footnotes are distinguished from the biblical text.

[1] Supplied research. LDS Gospel Topics Essays, compiled 366-page project PDF, physical pages 164-195, Mother in Heaven packet. An initial claim inventory and teaching resource, not independent corroboration of each historical claim.

[2] Official LDS explanation. Mother in Heaven, Gospel Topics Essays. Source for the Church's stated doctrine, documentary acknowledgment, and explanation of limited knowledge.

[3] Early published reference. William W. Phelps, Come to Me, Times and Seasons 6, no. 1, January 15, 1845, page 783. Reproduced passage and source metadata, B. H. Roberts Foundation. Used as a transcription of the early text; the host's claim to identify a first usage is not adopted as a comprehensive historical finding.

[4] Snow's text and historical editing. Eliza R. Snow, My Father in Heaven October 1845, The First Fifty Years of Relief Society. Reproduces the poem published November 15, 1845, and supplies editorial context. Note 4 cites Gates's 1911 history and David McKay's March 16, 1916 letter to Mrs. James Hood. The letter itself has not been independently examined here.

[5] A transmitted recollection. Susa Young Gates, History of the Young Ladies' Mutual Improvement Association of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, 1911, pages 15-16. Reproduced passage concerning Zina D. Young, B. H. Roberts Foundation. Gates names Zina as the teller; the surviving narrative is not Gates's eyewitness account of Smith's conversation.

[6] First Presidency statement. The Origin of Man, November 1909, reprinted in Ensign, February 2002. The reprint identifies the original as Improvement Era, November 1909, pages 75-81, and discloses standardized editorial features.

[7] Joint institutional declaration. The Family A Proclamation to the World, First Presidency and Council of the Twelve Apostles, issued 1995. Source for creation, heavenly parentage, premortal identity, and the temple and family connection.

[8] Prayer and exaltation instruction. Gordon B. Hinckley, Daughters of God, October 1991 general conference. Read the guidance about prayer alongside the treatment of women's celestial destiny and faithful people without an opportunity for marriage.

[9] Revelation and limits on speculation. Dale G. Renlund, Your Divine Nature and Eternal Destiny, April 2022 general conference. Source for the explicit claim of revelation, limited knowledge, and prayer instruction; it is not an original Smith-era record.

[10] Premortal parentage in a teaching manual. Our Heavenly Family, Gospel Principles, chapter 2, 2011. Explains literal spirit parentage before earthly life and relates human potential to Christ's Atonement.

[11] LDS marriage and exaltation texts. Doctrine and Covenants 131, especially verses 1-4, and 132, especially verses 19-20. The canonical wording establishes the LDS claim; headings and bracketed explanations are distinguished from the underlying text.

[12] Creation and human dignity. Genesis 1, especially verses 26-27, KJV. Both male and female humanity are included in the divine image. The comparison does not assume that every use of plural language identifies divine spouses.

[13] The biblical doctrine of God. KJV, Deuteronomy 6:4; Isaiah 44:6-8; John 1:1-3; Matthew 28:19; 1 Corinthians 8:4-6. These supply the stated Trinitarian comparison; the theological synthesis is identified as the project's interpretation.

[14] Maternal imagery. Isaiah 66, especially verses 10-13, KJV. The context includes maternal Jerusalem imagery and the Lord's comparison of divine comfort with a mother's comfort.

[15] Humanity as divine offspring. Acts 17, especially verses 24-29, KJV. Read offspring language within the speech about the Creator, human dependence, and the rejection of manufactured images of deity.

[16] New birth and adoption. John 1:12-13 and Romans 8:14-17, KJV. These address receiving Christ, adoption, and inheritance; they should not be substituted without explanation for every biblical use of divine offspring.

[17] Men and women in context. 1 Corinthians 11, especially verses 3-16, KJV. The interpretation considers the setting of worship and the surrounding discussion rather than isolating verse 11.

[18] Marriage and resurrection. Matthew 22:23-33 and 1 Corinthians 7:7-8, 32-35, KJV. The case considers the LDS distinction about prior sealings while stating the project's Christian assessment.

[19] Prayer salvation and truthful witness. KJV, Matthew 6:9; Acts 7:59; Ephesians 2:8-10, 18; 1 John 5:11-13; 1 Peter 3:15; Proverbs 18:13, 17. These ground the positive Christian invitation and the requirement to hear and represent another person's position accurately.

Collection notes

Case File 007 follows Priesthood Temples and Women and precedes Peace and Violence in the Nineteenth Century. The LDS collection begins with 00 and continues through Cases 001-012, followed by the separate Christian conversation guide. Later cases and the guide require their own completion and publication checks.